ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Why Is Minhah So Short?

Derech Hashem 4:6:15-17

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraphs 15-17 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 28 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: climbing the worlds

Last time the class learned the four worlds and how prayer climbs them: the korbanot correspond to the lowest world, Pesukei DeZimra to the second, Shema and its blessings to the third, and the Amidah to the fourth and highest, Asilut, the source of everything. As a participant had said, you cannot jump straight there; you must go up in order. At the top, in the Amidah, the energy is brought down.

After the Amidah, Hazal added three more things to increase the blessing and bring the energy down more effectively: confession (viduy), the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, and nefilat apayim.

Viduy: quietening the prosecutor (paragraph 15)

Confession closes the mouth of the prosecutors. The energy is about to come down, and the prosecutor says it is not deserved, and it is lost. As learned last year, the heavenly system works like a court here, with prosecutors and defence. This is also why one should not speak between the Amidah and Tahanun: you are bringing down energy and could ruin the connection.

The Rabbi drew a lesson for life: "If you admit your mistakes, people won't tell them to you." Better to admit them before you are told. So too here: once you have said them, there is nothing left for the prosecutor to say.

The Thirteen Attributes of Mercy

Next we say the Thirteen Attributes to increase God's mercy. The Rabbi recalled what was learned around Rosh Hashanah: someone who truly recognises Yihud Hashem can receive mercy even without merit. After the golden calf, Moshe prayed in the merit of Avraham, and God told him that this would one day run out, but one thing would never leave Israel empty-handed: the Thirteen Attributes. Saying them creates mercy even for those who are not deserving.

Nefilat apayim

Third comes nefilat apayim, "falling on the face", when we put our heads down on our arms. This is subduing ourselves before the Almighty: we are completely dependent on You. It too quietens the prosecutors, arouses great mercy, and brings the energy down in abundance.

The Rabbi stressed that sitting down for LeDavid is not just sitting down. Until about 500 years ago, as learned in the halachah classes, everyone did nefilat apayim after the Amidah. The Arizal said it is not done today, but Ashkenazim and many Sefaradim still do it, "because that's the whole idea."

He added that the Ben Ish Hai asks what happens on days without Tahanun, and answers that the holiness of the day brings the blessing down. Even a simhah, such as a berit milah, has that power.

The Ramhal says there are many more details, but this is the general picture of the prayer: up through the worlds, and then the descent.

Minhah and Arvit (paragraph 16)

The day divides into two parts, morning and afternoon, and the night into two, before and after midnight. In each of the four segments the energy of that time must be brought down, and so we have our set prayers.

Why is Shaharit an hour long and Minhah ten minutes? The morning is the renewal of the energy, the start of a new day, so Hazal instituted a long process going through everything. The afternoon follows on from the morning, so it only needs one thing to complete the day. We can rely on the climb we did in the morning and go straight to the Amidah.

The Rabbi pointed out that, strictly, Minhah is only the Amidah and nefilat apayim. LamNasseah and Ketoret are nice additions; Ashrei is said so that one comes to the Amidah settled ("Ashrei yoshvei vetekha"), and someone who had been meditating for an hour could begin the Amidah directly. Alenu and the rest were added later.

Arvit, however, has the Shema with its blessings. Although night is a continuation of the morning, it is more of a change than from morning to afternoon: "It's like a new thing. It's night time." So Hazal instituted a longer service, but shorter than the morning.

After midnight: left to the pious

What about the fourth segment, after midnight? Hazal did not want to burden us: it is dark and people are tired. They left it to the righteous and the pious, who get up, study, pray and say Tehillim. "That's a very, very special time, but I recognise it's too much to obligate it."

The Rabbi returned to praying first thing in the morning, criticising those who make phone calls, have breakfast and read the paper before Shaharit, and the late start of Shabbat morning prayers, which he called a mentality that has taken hold. "We have to pray first thing, to bring down the energy for the day, and then you get on with your day."

A participant asked about Minhah on Shabbat, said to be its high point. The Rabbi gave two explanations. On the simple level, after a big meal, when you feel lethargic, you still come back to the synagogue, so it is a time of favour. In Kabbalah, Seudah Shelishit is the greatest part of

Shabbat, the culmination of a day that builds up, from the soul received at night to the higher one in the morning, which is why we drop down at its end.

The forefathers and King David (paragraph 17)

The three prayers were instituted by the forefathers (Avraham Shaharit, Yishak Minhah, Yaakov Arvit), so they are obligatory for all. Rising at midnight to pray and sing to God is associated with David, the completion of the Avot, but since he is not on a par with the three forefathers it was not made obligatory. On holy days there is an extra prayer, Musaf, to draw down the extra holiness of the day.

This completes the daily misvot. The next chapter, perfectly timed before Pesah, turns to the seasonal misvot: Shabbat, Yom Tov and why Shabbat falls on the seventh day.

Summary

- After the Amidah, viduy silences the prosecutor, the Thirteen Attributes arouse mercy even without merit, and nefilat apayim expresses complete dependence on God.
- Shaharit is long because the morning renews everything; Minhah relies on the morning and is essentially just the Amidah.
- Arvit is longer than Minhah because night is a real change, but shorter than Shaharit.
- Rising after midnight was left to the pious, like King David, rather than made obligatory.
- The three daily prayers come from the forefathers; Musaf draws down the extra holiness of special days.

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